While many in the Tata Group supported the proposal, Russi Mody openly opposed it while Darbari Seth and Ajit Kerkar seemed to accept the inevitable. Mody even sent out signals that he would not be affected by the retirement policy, and he was there to stay.

Russi Mody

Russi Mody was a business legend. People saw him as a leader who led from the front. He was a people's person and had a natural connect with his workers. He was quick to understand the problems of the workers and resolved them expeditiously.

JRD had credited Mody with ensuring that TISCO did not lose even a single day on account of any labour issues, though it had a mammoth workforce of 70,000–80,000. There was hardly a time when stories of Mody's deft handling of the various company issues were not topics of discussion in Jamshedpur. Ratan, too, said that he was a member of the Mody fan club and admired his management skills.

TISCO did not have a strike for seventy-five years, comments Ishaat Hussain. But he is quick to add that Mody was the right person for the Licence Raj and not suited to a liberal system. He says that Mody would have been a 'disaster' in the new ecosystem.

Mody had not reconciled to having lost to Ratan in the race to be the group chairman. His absence at the board meeting in which Ratan was appointed as chairman was seen as the beginning of an open rift between the two. A business newspaper commented: 'This not only irreparably dented Mody's standing at Bombay House but would mark the start of a chapter of the growing rift between Mody and the Tatas.' Mody was, however, not willing to hang up his boots as yet, though many commented that his end was nigh. He had aspirations for his protégé, Aditya Kashyap.

On 26 November 1991, in an audacious move, Mody redesignated some senior TISCO staff. Kashyap was elevated as joint managing director, J.J. Irani was made the additional managing director and Ishaat Hussain was moved up as deputy managing director. Besides, Mody redesignated around 2,000 managers. He justified his actions stating that a report of the US-based consultancy firm, Arthur D. Little, had recommended certain redesignations of posts in TISCO.